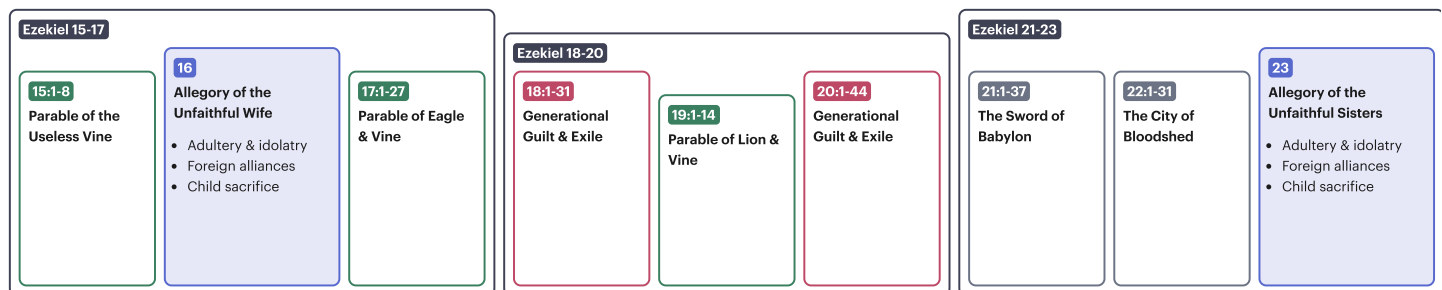


Session 12: Israel the Unfaithful Wife

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel engages in trash talk to equate Israel with their Canaanite neighbors.
- The Bible is for our good, but it doesn't always make us feel good.
- Difficult passages invite us to wrestle with God, seeking the blessing he has for us in the Bible.

Literary Design of Ezekiel 15-23: Oracles Against Israel



Ezekiel 15-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Ezekiel 15-17

This is a meaningful compositional unit because all three chapters depict/retell the story of an Eden plant/human who fails to live up to its divinely given potential and is given over to the consequences.

Chapter 15

- A vine-tree (עץ הגפן) that cannot be used for work
- "Will it succeed at work?" (היצלח למלאכה, [15:4](#))
- "I will make the land desolate, because they have committed treachery" (מעלו מעל, [15:8](#))

Chapter 16

- A naked, helpless girl who is rescued, clothed, adorned, and married, but who selfishly turns to other lovers (many analogies to Adam and Eve)
- "Will she succeed to a royal-kingdom?" (ותצלחי למלוכה, [16:13](#))

Chapter 17

- The royal-seed (זרע המלוכה) of Judah is planted by Babylon to be a vine (גפן), but it turns its roots to another master (Egypt) for water to produce fruit.

- "Will it succeed?" (התצלח, 17:10)
- "And he rebelled by sending messengers (מלאכיו) to Egypt ... Will he succeed?" (היצלח, 17:15)
- "I will enter into judgment with him ... for his treachery which he committed" (מעל ... מעל, 17:20).

Parable of the Useless Vine

The parable is about piece of wood taken from a grape vine stock that cannot be used for any building, carving, or hanging purposes. And, if it is a burned piece of wood, then how much more useless is it for any of these purposes.

The rhetorical question, "Will it succeed at any work?" (היצלח למלאכה, 15:4) is meant to invite the obvious answer, "No, it will not succeed."

The parable is quickly applied to "the inhabitants of Jerusalem" (15:6), who are going to be consumed by a "fire" which will result in the desolation of the land because of their treachery (הארץ שממה and מעלו מעל in 15:8 are link words back to 14:13 and 15-16).

However, there is more to this parable. The image of the "tree-vine" (עץ הגפן) is not only an analogy to the royal-priestly humans in the Eden story (see the design of Gen. 2:4-9), but is an explicit metaphor for the royal line of David elsewhere in the Psalms and prophets.

In 15:3, "Can they take from it a peg to hang any items upon it?" mirrors Isaiah 22:22-25, where the king from the house of David is a "peg" meant for "the hanging of items," that is, the royal house and its honor (see also Ps. 80:14-17, where the vine is an image of the royal son of David).

Parable of Israel as the Lewd Prostitute

Ezekiel adopts the Torah and earlier prophets' metaphor of Israel's covenant faithlessness as marital infidelity and prostitution (Exod. 34:15-16; Deut. 31:16; Hos. 1-3; Jer. 2:20-25). But he uniquely develops the images into a long (longest oracle among the prophets!) stomach-turning, shocking allegory that undermines Israel's entire view of its own history (*zanah/zenut*, "to have illicit sex as a prostitute" occurs 21x in this one chapter).

Ezekiel 16:1-14

- **16:1-5** Israel of Canaanite, Amorite, Hittite birth, an abandoned infant found
- **16:6-8** Yahweh rescues, clothes, and enters into a covenant with her
- **16:9-14** Yahweh provides her with clothes, food, and royal beauty

Ezekiel 16:15-43

16:15-22

- She takes her **beauty, clothes, and food, and children** and becomes a **prostitute** with idol gods

16:23-34

- She takes her **beauty, clothes, and food** and becomes a **prostitute** for the nations

16:35-43

- Yahweh gathers her lovers who take away her beauty, clothes, and food and publicly execute her as an adulterous **prostitute**

Ezekiel 16:44-63

- **16:44-47** **Israel of Amorite and Hittite birth**, with **Samaria** and **Sodom** as sisters
- **16:48-58** Israel's behavior makes **Sodom** and **Samaria** look righteous
- **16:59-63** Yahweh **will remember his covenant** and restore Israel, **Sodom**, and **Samaria**

Ezekiel 16:1-63. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

¹ And the word of Yahweh came to me saying,

² "Son of a human,
make known to Jerusalem its abominations.

³ And you will say,

'Thus says Yahweh Elohim to Jerusalem:

**Your origins and place of birth are from the land of the Canaanite;
your father was an Amorite,
and your mother was a Hittite.**

⁴ And as **for your birth,**

on the day you were born,
your navel string was not cut,
nor were you washed with water for cleansing,
nor were you rubbed with salt,
nor were you wrapped in cloth.

⁵ No eye had pity on you to do any of these things for you,
so as to have compassion on you,
and you were cast on the face of the ground,
when you were an object of loathing,

on the day you were born.

⁶ **And I passed you by,**

and I saw you kicking in your blood,
and I said to you in your blood, "Live!"
and I said to you in your blood, "Live!"

⁷ I made you great, like a plant of the field,
and you became great and grew up,

and you came into the best of ornaments,
your breasts became firm,
and your hair grew,
and you were naked and bare.

⁸ **And I passed you by** and I saw you and look,
your time was the time for love;
and I spread my garment over you,
and I covered your **nakedness**,
and **I swore an oath to you**,
and **I entered into a covenant** with you,
and you became mine,
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

⁹ And I washed you with water,
and I washed off your blood from upon you,
and I anointed you with **oil**,

¹⁰ and **I clothed you** with **embroidered clothing**,
and I furnished you with sandals of sea-cow skin,
and I bound you with **linen**,
and I covered you with **fine cloth**,

¹¹ and I set **ornaments** upon you,
and I set bracelets on your hands,
and a necklace on your neck,

¹² and I set a ring in your nose and an earring in your ear,
and a splendid crown on your head,

¹³ and you were adorned with gold and silver,
and your clothing was **linen** and **fine cloth** and **embroidered cloth**;
you ate **flour and honey and oil**,
and you became **extremely beautiful**,
and you prospered unto royalty.

¹⁴ And a name went out for you among the nations due to **your beauty**,
for it was perfect,
due to my splendor which I had placed upon you,
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁵ But you trusted in **your beauty**,
and you acted like a **prostitute** because of your name,
and you poured out your **prostitution** on every one who passed by,
it became his.

¹⁶ **And you took** some of your **clothes**,
and you made for yourself variegated high places,
and you played the **prostitute** with them.
Not coming things, nor will it be.

¹⁷ **And you took** your **beautiful items** of my gold and my silver which I gave you,
and you made for yourself male images,

and you played the **prostitute** with them.

¹⁸ **And you took** your **embroidered clothing**,
and you covered them,
and you set my **oil** and my incense before them,

¹⁹ and my bread which I gave you,
fine flour and oil and honey which I fed you,
so you set it before them as a pleasant aroma.

And so it was,
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

²⁰ **And you took** your sons and your daughters whom you bore for me,
and you sacrificed them to them [i.e., the male images] for eating.

Were your **prostitution** too small a thing,

²¹ that you sacrificed my sons,
and that you gave them up,
so as to offer them up to them?

²² And with regard to all your abominations and your **prostitution**,
you did not remember the days of your youth,
when you were **naked and bare**,
when you were kicking in your blood.

²³ And it came about after all your wickedness,
woe! woe to you,
utterance of Yahweh Elohim,

²⁴ **that you built for yourself a ritual mound**,
and you made for yourself a high place in every square,

²⁵ at the head of every street you built your high place,
and you made **your beauty** abominable,
and you spread your legs to every passerby,
and you multiplied your **prostitution**,

²⁶ and you played the **prostitute** with the sons of Egypt,
your neighbors with large penises,
and you multiplied your **prostitution** so as to provoke me,

²⁷ and look, I stretched out my hand against you,
and I withdrew your portion,
and I gave you to the appetite of your adversaries,
the sons of the Philistines,

who were ashamed because of your shameful conduct,
²⁸ and you played the **prostitute** with the sons of Assyria,
because you were not satisfied,
and you played the **prostitute** with them,
and again you were not satisfied,

²⁹ and you multiplied your **prostitution** with the land of trade, with the Chaldeans,
and again you were not satisfied.

³⁰ How weak is your heart,
utterance of Yahweh Elohim,

while you do all these things,
the acts of a domineering **prostitute** .

31 **When you built your ritual mound at the head of every street ,**
and you built your high place in every square ,

then you were not like a **prostitute** ,
for (you) scoffed at the wages of a **prostitute** .

32 The adulteress woman takes strangers instead of her husband.

33 People give gifts to most **prostitutes** ,
but you give your gifts to all your lovers,
and you bribe them to come to you from all around in your **prostitution** .

34 And so you are the opposite of other women in your **prostitution** ,
for you were not sought as a **prostitution** ,
but when you give away a **prostitute's** wage and none is given to you,
you are the opposite.

35 Therefore O prostitute, hear the word of Yahweh:

36 Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Because you poured out your sexual lewdness,
and you exposed your nakedness in your **prostitution**
to your lovers and to the idols of your abominations,
and according to the bloodshed of your sons which you gave over to them [i.e., the idols],

37 therefore, I am about to gather all your lovers to whom you were pleasing,
and everyone whom you loved,
everyone whom you hated,
and I will gather them against you from all around,
and I will expose your nakedness to them,
and they will see all your nakedness.

38 I will judge you by the customs of adulterous women,
and of those who shed blood,
and I will bring on you blood and anger and zeal.

39 And I will give you into their hands,
and they will tear down your ritual mound ,
and they will demolish your high places ,
and I will strip you of your clothes,
and they will take all the ornaments of **your beauty** ,
and I will leave you **naked and bare**.

40 And they will bring a crowd around,
and they will stone you with stones,
and will cut you up with their swords.

41 And they will burn your houses with fire,
and will execute judgments against you in the sight of many women,
and I will make you stop your **prostitution** ,
and you will no longer give away your **prostitute's** wages.

42 And I will give rest to my anger against you,
and my zeal will turn away from you,

and I will be calm and no longer be angry.

43 **Because you did not remember the days of your youth**,
and you troubled me with all these things,
and look, I myself will bring your way on your head,
utterance of Yahweh Elohim,
and you will not act lewdly in all your abominations.

44 Behold, everyone who tells parables about you will tell a parable saying,
"Like mother, like daughter."

45 You are the daughter of your mother,
abhorring her husband and her children,
and you are **a sister of your sister**,
who abhorred their husbands and their children,
your mother was a Hittite,
and your father was an Amorite.

46 And **your older sister** was **Samaria**,
she and her children who dwell on your left,
and **your sister younger** than you on your right was **Sodom** and her children.

47 But you did not walk in their ways,
and you acted according to their abominations;
just a brief moment and you became more corrupt than they in all of your ways.

48 As I live, utterance of Yahweh Elohim,
Sodom and her children have not done as you and your children have done.

49 Look, this was the sin of **Sodom your sister**:
She and her children had pride, satiation with food, and careless relaxation,
and she did not assist the hand of the poor and needy.

50 But they became exalted,
and acted abominably before me,
and I removed them, just as I have seen.

51 And **Samaria** did not sin half as much as your sins,
but you made more abominations than they;
so **you have made your sisters appear more righteous**,
due to all the abominations you have done.

52 So you, carry your disgrace,
because you have interceded for **your sister** with your sins,
which you have made more abominable than they;
they are more righteous than you !

So you too, be ashamed and bear you disgrace,
because **you have made your sister appear righteous**.

53 And I will **restore their fortune**,
the fortune of **Sodom** and her children,
and the fortune of **Samaria** and her children,
and I will **restore your fortunes** along with them,

54 so that you may bear your disgrace,

and be disgraced of all that you did,
thereby become a source of comfort for them.

55 And **your sister Sodom** and her children will **return to their former state**,
and **Samaria** and her children will **return to their former state**,
and you and your children will **return to your former state**.

56 And **Sodom your sister** was not a report in your mouth in the day of your pride,
57 before your wickedness was uncovered, now the reproach of Aram,
and all the daughters of the Philistines around who despise you, it's all around,
58 You have borne your lewdness and your abominations,
utterance of Yahweh.

59 For thus says Yahweh Elohim,
so I shall do to you just as you have done,
as you despised the oath so as to violate **the covenant** .

60 But **I will remember my covenant with you** in the days of your youth,
and **I will make with you an eternal covenant** ;

61 and **you will remember** your ways and you will be disgraced,
when you receive **your sister** older and younger than you,
and I will give them to you as **sisters**,
but not from **your covenant** .

62 But **I will make my covenant with you**,
and you will know that I am Yahweh.

63 In order that you may remember and be ashamed,
and never have again a gaping mouth because of your shame,
when I have made atonement for you,
for everything that you've done;
utterance of Yahweh Elohim.

Ezekiel 16:1-63. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Revisionist Step #1 (Ezek. 16:1-14): Reimagining Israel's Beginnings

Ezekiel begins by reshaping Israel's "pagan" origins (see [Deut. 26:5-10](#); [Josh. 24:1-2](#)) into a racial slur that places Israel among the pagan nations it despised (Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites).

Israel is then envisioned as an unwanted and abandoned infant. Yahweh declares life to the nearly dead infant (link to [chapter 37](#)) and enters into a covenant betrothal ("spreading the garment" indicates betrothal, see also [Ruth 3:9](#)).

Israel's abundance and beauty is a complete and total gift from Yahweh, not an inherent possession.

Revisionist Step #2 (Ezek. 16:15-34): Reimagining Israel's Rise to Power

Israel forgot its existence was due solely to the generous gift of Yahweh and "you trusted in your beauty" (see [Deut. 8:17-18](#)).

“The temptation to make the gifts of God the objects of trust instead of trusting the giver himself is one that has never failed to snare God’s people through history ... In fact, the more gifted you are, the greater is this temptation.”

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [*The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit*](#). IVP Academic. 136-137.

The “high places” in 16:16 refer to the hilltop shrines dedicated to Asherah the fertility goddess ([1 Kgs. 3:2-4](#), [12:31-32](#), [14:23](#)) where ritual sex was part of worship. Ezekiel exploits both images in his allegory.

Children who belong to Yahweh (as giver of life) were abusively given to the Canaanite gods (for historical references see [2 Kgs. 16:3](#), [17:16-17](#); [Jer. 32:35](#)). And Israel made political alliances with other nations (Egypt, Canaan, Babylon, verses 26-29).

Revisionist Step #3 (Ezek. 16:35-43): Reimagining the Exile

Ezekiel’s purpose is to get his listener to agree that a humiliating death is a fully warranted and deserved sentence for such behavior (marriage covenant violation, illicit prostitution, murder, arrogance).

The story ends as it began: naked, bloody, helpless.

Revisionist Step #4 (Ezek. 16:44-58): Reimagining Israel’s Tribal History

Later, in [Ezekiel 23](#), the prophet plays this allegory out in detail. In this reimagining, Samaria and Sodom are Jerusalem’s closest relatives.

Revisionist Step #5 (Ezek. 16:59-63): Reimagining Israel’s Future Hope

Yahweh gives a glimpse of future hope in covenant renewal. “I will remember my covenant with you” deliberately echoes [Genesis 8:1](#), [Exodus 2:23-24](#), and [Leviticus 26:43-45](#).

The phrase “eternal covenant” (also in [37:26](#)) is used in the Hebrew Bible to describe God’s covenant with creation ([Gen. 9:16](#)), with Abraham and his family ([Gen. 17:7](#), [13](#), [19](#); [Ps. 105:10](#)), the Sabbath ([Exod. 31:16](#)), the covenant with David ([2 Sam. 23:5](#); [Isa 55:3](#)), and the eschatological renewal of the covenant ([Isa. 61:8](#); [Jer. 32:40](#); [Ezek. 37:26](#)).

Other nations are included. Samaria and Sodom are “received as daughters even though they are not your covenant partners” (16:61).

Israel will have no grounds for defensive anger for the exile (= “no open mouth”). Through this process of judgment Yahweh will provide atonement/covering for all of Israel’s covenant violation.

Ezekiel 17: Parable of the Eagle and the Vine

A vine that is taken up by an eagle and planted by a river discovers another eagle and turns its attention toward it and withers as a result.

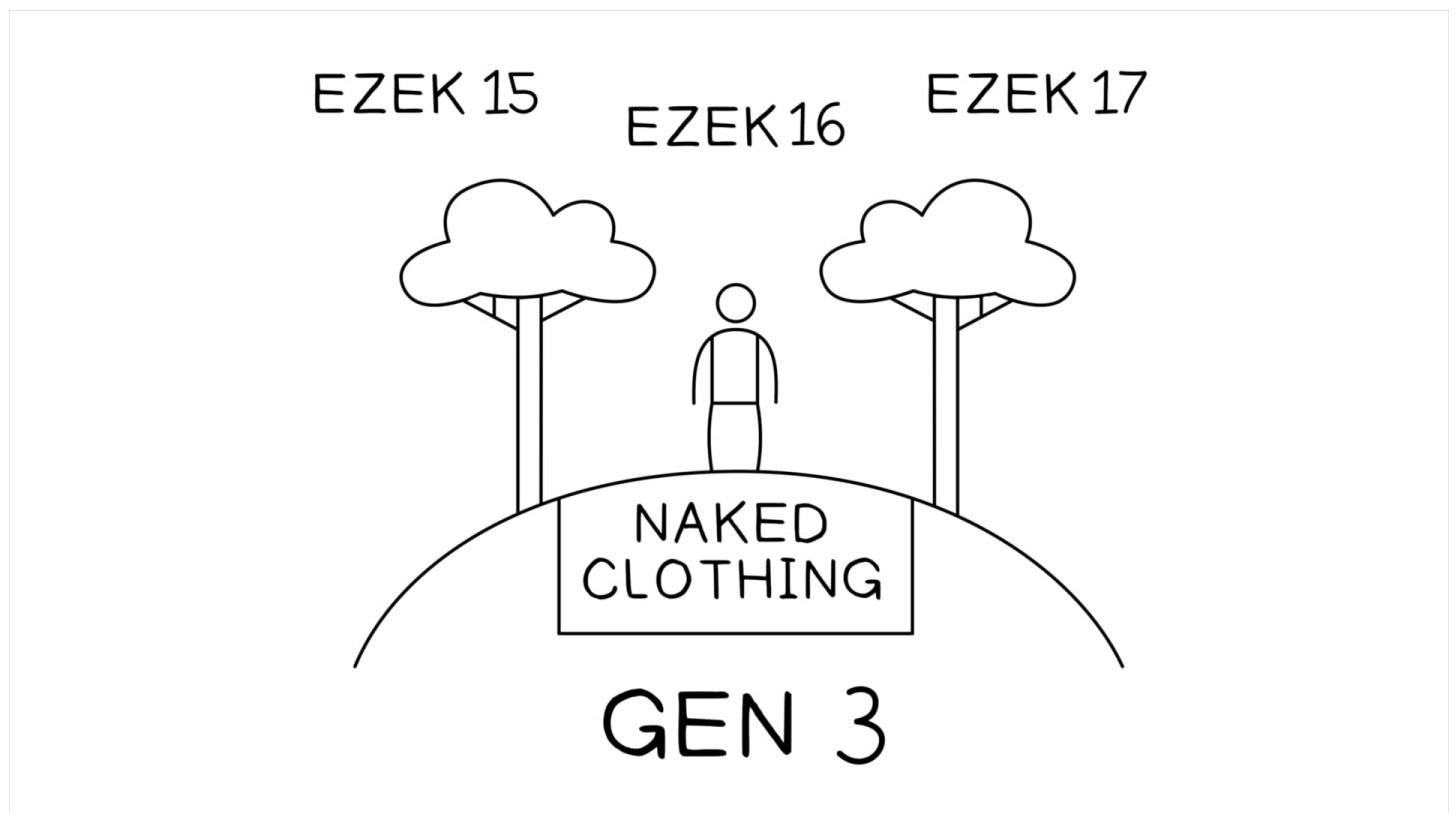
Application to Zedekiah's Rebellion

Babylon took King Jehoiachin into exile ([2 Kgs. 24:11-15](#)) and set up his uncle Zedekiah as a puppet-king ([2 Kgs. 24:17](#)). He secretly joined a rebel alliance with Israel's neighbors ([Jer. 27:1-7](#)), appealing to Egypt for assistance in resisting Babylon ([2 Kgs. 24:19](#) hints at this; see [Jer. 37:3-8](#)).

Future Hope for the Vine

Ezekiel now depicts Yahweh as the eagle and the vine as the royal line of David (a stock motif in the prophets, see [Isa. 11:1](#); [Jer. 23:5](#); [Zech. 3:8](#), [6:12](#)), that will be planted on a "high mountain" (link forward to [40:1-2](#)) and become a great tree bearing fruit and attracting creatures. This is the first word of hope for the line of David, and it points forward to the messianic promises of chapters 34-37.

Ezekiel 15-17 Mirrors Genesis 3



Ezekiel 15-17 Mirrors Genesis 3. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

What aspects of the parable in Ezekiel 16 are most challenging for you? How do you honor the difficulties yet continue to engage with Scripture?